

Rugby For Good
Benefits Realisation Framework

Prepared by Balmoral Group Australia for

The NSW Positive Rugby Foundation

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Balmoral Group of Australia is located in Sydney and Brisbane. Sydney is where the head office of Balmoral Group Australia resides. It is the traditional home of the Gadigal Aboriginal people of the Eora Nation. Brisbane was founded upon the homelands of the Turrbal and Yuggera peoples, whose Country stretches north from Elimbah Creek, south to the Logan River and inland as far as Moggill. The authors acknowledge the Traditional Owners of Country throughout Australia and recognise their continuing connection to land, waters and culture. We pay our respects to their Elders, past and present.

KEY PROPOSAL DETAILS

PROPOSAL INFORMATION	
Proposal name	*Rugby For Good* Cost Benefit Analysis_ Updated report
Lead proponent (e.g. Council)	NSW Positive Rugby Foundation
Lead proponent ABN	
Proposal partners	
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PROPOSAL SCOPE	
Proposal summary for publication *Please provide 150 words or less*	The NSW Positive Rugby Foundation is improving outcomes through their *Rugby For Good* programs which aim to improve the health and well-being of communities through rugby. It analyses the benefits of current programs to justify investment in the programs.
PROPOSAL LOCATION	
Proposal address	
Local government area	
NSW electorate	
Federal electorate	
SUPPORTING INFORMATION	
Attachments *Please list out all supporting information provided*	

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1 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The NSW Positive Rugby Foundation's *Rugby For Good* program drives economic and social benefits while expanding rugby's reach across New South Wales. Unlike traditional funding models reliant on Rugby Australia, registration fees, and event revenues, *Rugby For Good* is a comprehensive initiative that fosters both financial sustainability and social impact through targeted programs.

To ensure measurable and lasting benefits, the *Rugby For Good* Benefit Realisation Management (BRM) framework provides a structured and adaptable methodology for tracking program outcomes. Grounded in Cost-Benefit Analysis (CBA) findings, the framework addresses the challenges of early-stage benefit measurement by offering a clear roadmap for stakeholders to monitor progress, evaluate success, and refine strategies for enhanced impact.

The BRM framework focuses on eight key benefit areas: increasing rugby participation, improving educational attainment, reducing anxiety and depression, breaking mental health stigma, enhancing physical health, strengthening community ties, ensuring club sustainability, and expanding employment opportunities. Each benefit area is supported by baseline assumptions, key performance indicators (KPIs), and measurable targets, with data from existing surveys and newly developed metrics serving as benchmarks for assessing effectiveness. Figure 1 summarises the expected outcomes of the programs, which offer various benefits to stakeholders, from personal development to broader community advantages

Figure 1. Expected Outcomes from *Rugby For Good*



Source: BGA Work Product

A core component of the framework is the continuous monitoring and evaluation of performance across program locations. It establishes clear accountability for data collection, reporting frequency, and performance targets, ensuring alignment among participants, schools, and local clubs. Additionally, the framework incorporates a risk management strategy to mitigate potential challenges, such as unrealistic targets, inadequate data collection, staffing constraints, and weak stakeholder engagement.

To quantify these initiatives' economic and social returns, the NSW Positive Rugby Foundation engaged Balmoral Group Australia to conduct a Cost-Benefit Analysis (CBA) of three flagship programs: Tackle Life, Holiday Break Camps, and Start Talking & Get Talkin'. The analysis confirmed that the benefits significantly outweighed the costs, with Benefit-Cost Ratios (BCRs) of 5.78, 3.14, and 3.63, respectively. These programs collectively impact thousands of participants annually, demonstrating strong returns on investment and substantial community benefits.

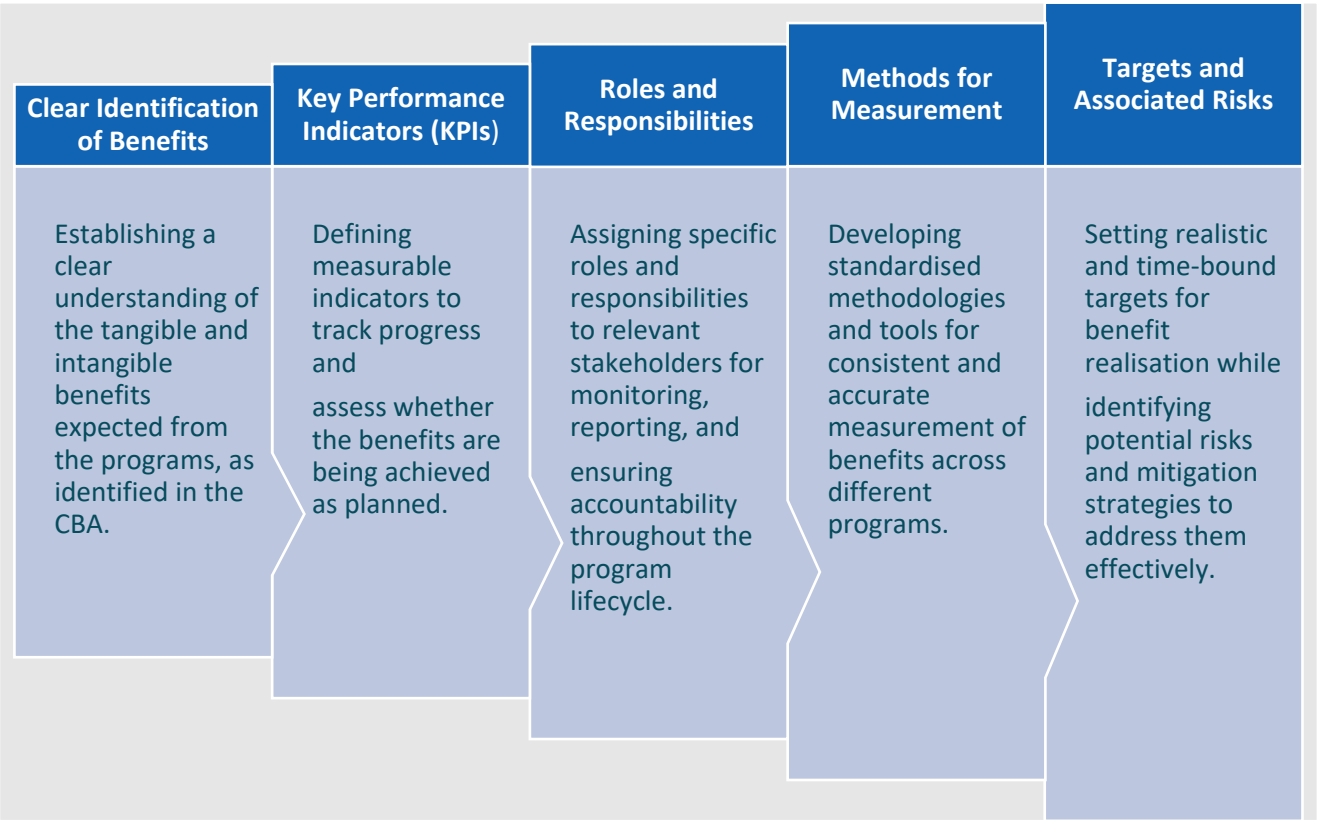
Beyond growing rugby participation, *Rugby For Good* aligns with the Foundation's broader strategic goals, including community engagement, athlete development pathways, and financial sustainability. The findings reaffirm that continued investment in these programs will generate enduring economic, social, and community benefits. Expanding and strengthening *Rugby For Good* will further enhance its positive impact, ensuring a lasting legacy for rugby and the wider community.

2 BENEFITS REALISATION

2.1 Introduction

The Benefit Realisation Management (BRM) framework builds upon the CBA findings by outlining a structured approach to track and assess the identified benefits. Given that the programs are relatively new, there are inherent challenges in tracking and measuring benefits. For example, initial data may not be immediately available, and forecasting long-term outcomes can be uncertain. Despite these challenges, the BRM framework provides a dynamic and adaptable roadmap that allows stakeholders to monitor progress effectively, measure success, and make data-driven decisions to enhance program outcomes. This flexibility is key to ensuring the program's long-term success. The framework incorporates several essential components that guide the tracking of program benefits and overall effectiveness, as depicted in Figure 2.

Figure 2: Benefits Realisation Framework components



Source: BGA Work Product

These components collectively form a comprehensive framework that will be detailed in the following sections of this report. Through this framework, stakeholders will be able to track and realise the expected benefits, ensuring the program delivers long-term value to its participants and the broader community.

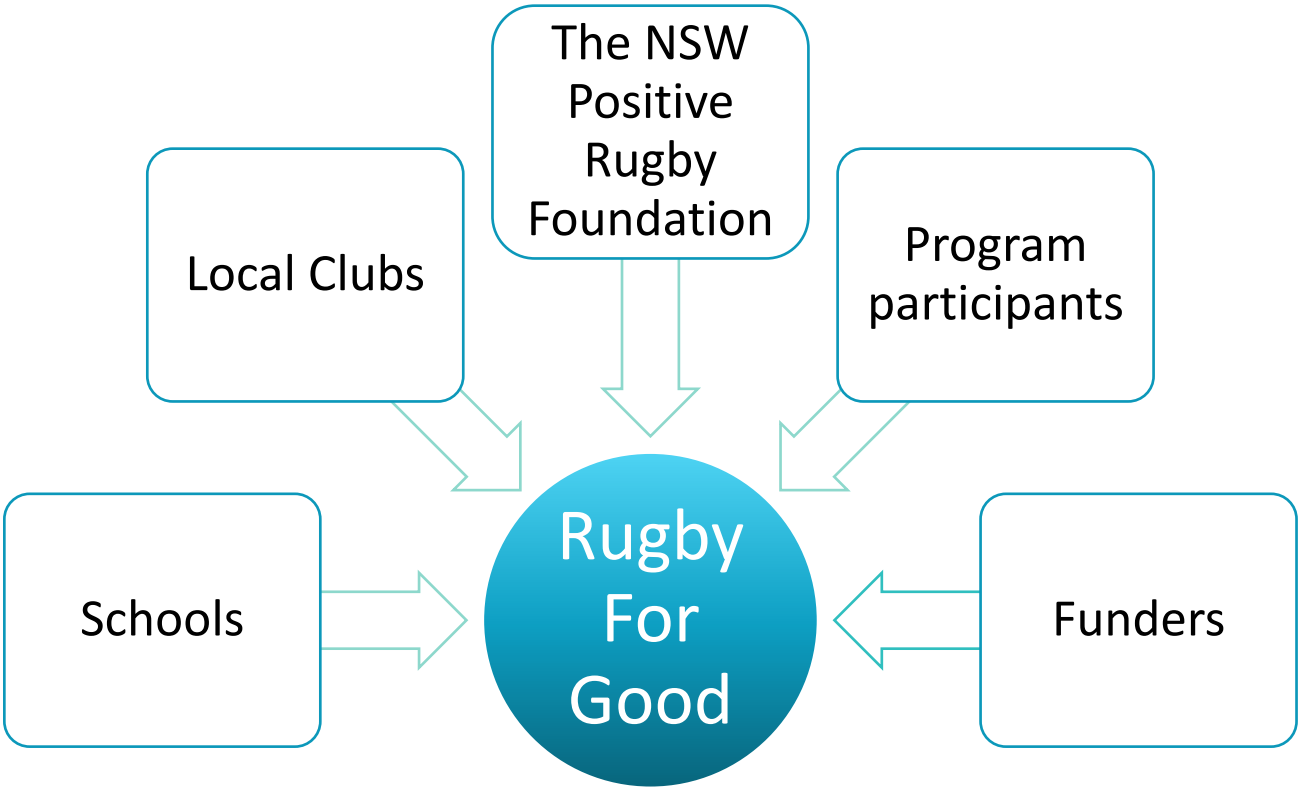
2.2 Scope

The scope of this framework is specifically focused on the *Rugby For Good* programs, aiming to track and assess measurable benefits related to participation, mental health improvements, and

strengthening community ties. The framework will include the identification and setting of Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) for these outcomes, with a particular emphasis on gathering baseline data or developing new metrics to ensure that the program's success can be quantified and evaluated. The framework will define responsibilities for monitoring and reporting on these KPIs, ensuring that all stakeholders are aligned in their efforts to achieve the program's objectives.

Key stakeholders include program participants, schools, and local clubs as shown in Figure 3. These groups will play a crucial role in both the execution of the programs and the monitoring of progress.

Figure 3: *Rugby For Good* BRF Key Stakeholders



Source: BGA Work Product

The BRM framework will also include risk assessments to identify potential obstacles to success and develop strategies to address them proactively. By maintaining a focus on specific, actionable outcomes, the framework ensures that the program stays on track and meets its intended goals.

While the framework aims to capture a broad range of beneficial outcomes, it does not focus on broader societal impacts. Instead, the emphasis is on specific, measurable outcomes that can directly influence the program's success and contribute to its long-term sustainability. This targeted approach ensures that the program remains practical, focused, and aligned with its goals.

2.3 Benefit Measurement and Baseline Setting

Table 1 summarises the different measures and baseline assumptions for each identified benefit. Where possible, baselines have been derived from existing participation surveys conducted by the NSW Positive Rugby Foundation. These serve as a benchmark for assessing program effectiveness. In cases where data is not yet available, baseline metrics have been established to provide a starting point for tracking and measuring program outcomes over time. These baseline assumptions ensure consistency in evaluation and support the ongoing monitoring of program impacts.

Table 1. Proposal Objectives

Benefit	Key Measures	Baseline Assumptions
Increased Participation	The Rugby Tackle Life program provides the most opportunities for youth to be involved in rugby. As such, the key measures are: • Existing schools & clubs continuing the Rugby Tackle Life program • Increase in new schools & clubs offering the Rugby Tackle Life program • Increase in player involvement in local clubs • Continued program attendance	In 2023, 17 schools or clubs offered the rugby tackle life program—13 in Western Sydney and 4 in the Dubbo Hub. Ausplay recently released participation survey data for 2023-24 in NSW. Results showed that: 26% of 15-17-year-olds in NSW participated in an activity organised by a sports club or association. 9-11 was 36.6%, 12-14 was 36.9%, and 18-24 was 20.2%. Additionally, the Foundation ran 127 Holiday Break camps over two years (an average of 64 per year) and 52 Get Talkin' programs over three years (an average of 17 per year).
Increased Education Attainment	• Student school attendance rates • Graduation rates	Lamb and Huo (2017) estimated that 12% of the 19-year-old population in Australia left school before completing Year 12 and were likely to never return. The CBA assumes that participation in the Rugby Tackle Life program will lower the dropout rate by 4%.
Reduced Anxiety and Depression	The number of participants reporting in surveys reduced anxiety and depression.	The NSW Positive Rugby Foundation has already performed surveys from previous programs. The 2020 Rugby Benefits Participation Report showed that 97% of participants showed improvements in health and well-being. The Get Talkin 2022/23[1]. The report showed that 62% (on average) indicated they would seek help if needed. These are the baseline indicators.

[1] Batyr & NSW Positive Rugby. 2022/2023 Feedback Summary Report

Reduced Stigma	Participant sentiment surveys comparing pre and post-program participation that provide the following information: • Number of mental health awareness activities • Participant engagement in programs • Reduced personal stigma	From the same participation survey as above, the average percentage of participants who felt engaged at four different locations in 2022 was 80%, with the lowest being 69%. Additionally, in the same survey, the average percentage of youth who held a negative internal stigma against themselves was 44%. These serve as an initial benchmark for increasing (in the case of engagement) or decreasing (for personal stigma).
Improved physical health	Improvements in physical health condition from programs that include physical activity, such as the Rugby Tackle Life: • Number of days per week a participant engages in physical activity	The Department of Health considers a child to be physically active when they do at least 60 minutes of moderate to vigorous activity per day, at least 3 days per week. Ausplay's participation survey results showed that in 2023-24, 48.4% of 15-17-year-olds in NSW participated in physical activity 3 or more times per week. For 9-11 was 19.3%, 12-14 was 23.9% and 18-24 was 47.2%. The CBA split improved physical health benefits among those who don't get injured (74%) and the net avoided healthcare costs for those who do (26%). Meaning that the physical condition of every Rugby Tackle Life participant should improve.
Stronger Community ties	Participant sentiment surveys comparing pre and post-program participation that provide the following information: • How well clubs/schools are engaged with the community • Improvements in sense of belonging & cohesion	The 2020 Rugby Benefits participation report shows that 39% of players in NSW were from disadvantaged postcodes. Additionally, surveys conducted by the NSW Positive Rugby Foundation have already tracked a sense of belonging as a result of participation in the rugby tackle life program. In 2023, students who were part of the program reported a 10.4% increase in optimism and sense of belonging.
Sustainable Clubs	Clubs being more financially and socially sustainable and less reliable on historical funding sources	This is not currently tracked, but the goal is to use income statements to see whether total revenues increased while the share that comes from traditional funding sources declined.
Sustainable employment	Key measures include: • Number of First Nations SBATs • Number employed to run the programs	Currently, Rugby Tackle Life has 12 SBATs. However, the program is being offered in more locations, which offers the opportunity to increase the number of SBATs where there are none.

Source: BGA Work Product

2.4 Monitoring and Reporting

Given that *Rugby For Good* programs are relatively new, data collection in a standardised manner is essential to monitor impacts across programs. Table 2 summarises targets, the primary responsibility of tracking and frequency. As the programs grow, these metrics should be adjusted as necessary.

Table 2. Benefits Targets and Monitoring

Benefit	Target	Responsibility	Frequency
Increased Participation	No existing programs dropping out from one year to another	Program Manager at each location	Annually
	Expand Rugby Tackle Life across all 3 hubs. Add at least one school or club in each hub		Annually
	Encourage program participants to join local clubs (playing or non-playing roles) to promote continued self-development. Start tracking how many participants join and stay active at their local clubs to set a benchmark. When it is lower than the NSW average, the target is to close the gap and be within those averages. When it is at or above, the target is a 10% increase in engagement with local clubs		Quarterly
	Continued participation is crucial for seeing lasting mental health benefits. As such, tracking session-to-session attendance for programs (any type) that hold multiple sessions at one location is needed. Attendance should align with how engaging participants found the programs from participation surveys.		Every session
Increased Education Attainment	Achieve 92% graduation rates from Rugby Tackle Life participants Monitor and report reduced school dropout rates of 4% compared to baseline.	Program Manager/Schools	Annually
Reduced Anxiety and Depression	80% of program participants report reduced anxiety and depression 97% of program participants reporting a better mental health and well-being because of participation in a program	Program Manager Organisations	Beginning and end of the program
Reduced Stigma	At least 64 Holiday Break camps and 17 Get Talkin' sessions delivered in a year. Goal for every year afterwards is to at least match the previous year.	Program Manager	Annually
	More than 80% of participants indicating they found the programs engaging		At the beginning and end of the program

	At least 70% of players indicating that they would seek help if they need it. Less than 40% of program participants holding a negative internal stigma around mental health issues		At the beginning and end of the program
Improve physical health	Initial survey to ask participants for time and frequency of physical activity. Target by the end of the Tackle Life program: • Aim for participants to reach the 3 days a week or add one day of physical activity to their routines. • Track how participants in program compare with overall NSW over time. • 100% of participants reporting improved physical condition.	Program Manager Coaches	Before program starts, mid-point and at the end
Stronger Community ties	Higher year-over-year number of community day events and increased attendance to such events.	Program Manager	Annually
	Higher year-over-year participation in disadvantaged neighbourhoods and exceed the 39% highlighted in the previous section.		Annually
	At least a 10% increase in the sense of optimism & belonging as a result of being part of a program		Before program starts, mid-point and at the end
Sustainable Clubs	Increase in total revenues while reducing the share that comes from traditional funding sources	Clubs	Annually
Sustainable employment	Aim to have at least one SBAT at every Rugby Tackle Life and holiday camp location	Program Manager	Annually
	Year-over-year growth in full-time equivalent jobs to run the programs	Program Manager	Annually

Source: BGA Work Product

3 IMPLEMENTATION CASE

3.1 Risk Assessment

A successful benefit realisation framework relies on the identification of attainable and measurable benefits, as well as active participation from all involved stakeholders. In assessing the programs, the business case has identified several risks that could impact the practical realisation of benefits. These risks arise from various aspects of program implementation, including data collection, stakeholder engagement, and the setting of realistic targets. Table 3 summarises the key risks that could hinder the measurement and monitoring of the identified benefits and outlines their potential impact on the programs' success.

Table 3: BRM Implementation Risk Assessment Matrix

Risk Factor	Impact	Consequence	Likelihood	Risk Rating	Assessment
Unrealistic Targets	Targets may become unattainable or misaligned with actual program progress, leading to inaccurate assessments of program effectiveness.	Medium	High	Medium	Likely in the early stages, less frequent over time
Inadequate & Insufficient Data Collection	Lack of consistent, reliable data can compromise the measurement of program benefits and make it difficult to track progress or adjust strategies.	High	High	High	High in the early stages, decreases with structured data collection processes
Insufficient Staff & Overdependence on Key Personnel	Over-reliance on limited staff may result in resource shortages or bottlenecks, hindering program progress and delivery of benefits.	High	Moderate	Medium	Moderate, potentially increases as the program expands
Weak Stakeholder Engagement	Lack of active participation from stakeholders may lead to disengagement, undermining the tracking and realisation of benefits.	High	High	High	Likely at the start, can decrease with strong communication and engagement efforts

3.2 Risk Management

Risk management is crucial for the successful implementation of the Benefits Realisation Framework. This section outlines strategies to mitigate key risks, including unrealistic targets, data collection gaps, staffing shortages, and weak stakeholder engagement. Proactively addressing these risks will help ensure the program meets its objectives and delivers the desired outcomes. Table 4 presents the proposed mitigation strategies for each identified risk.

Table 4. Key Risks

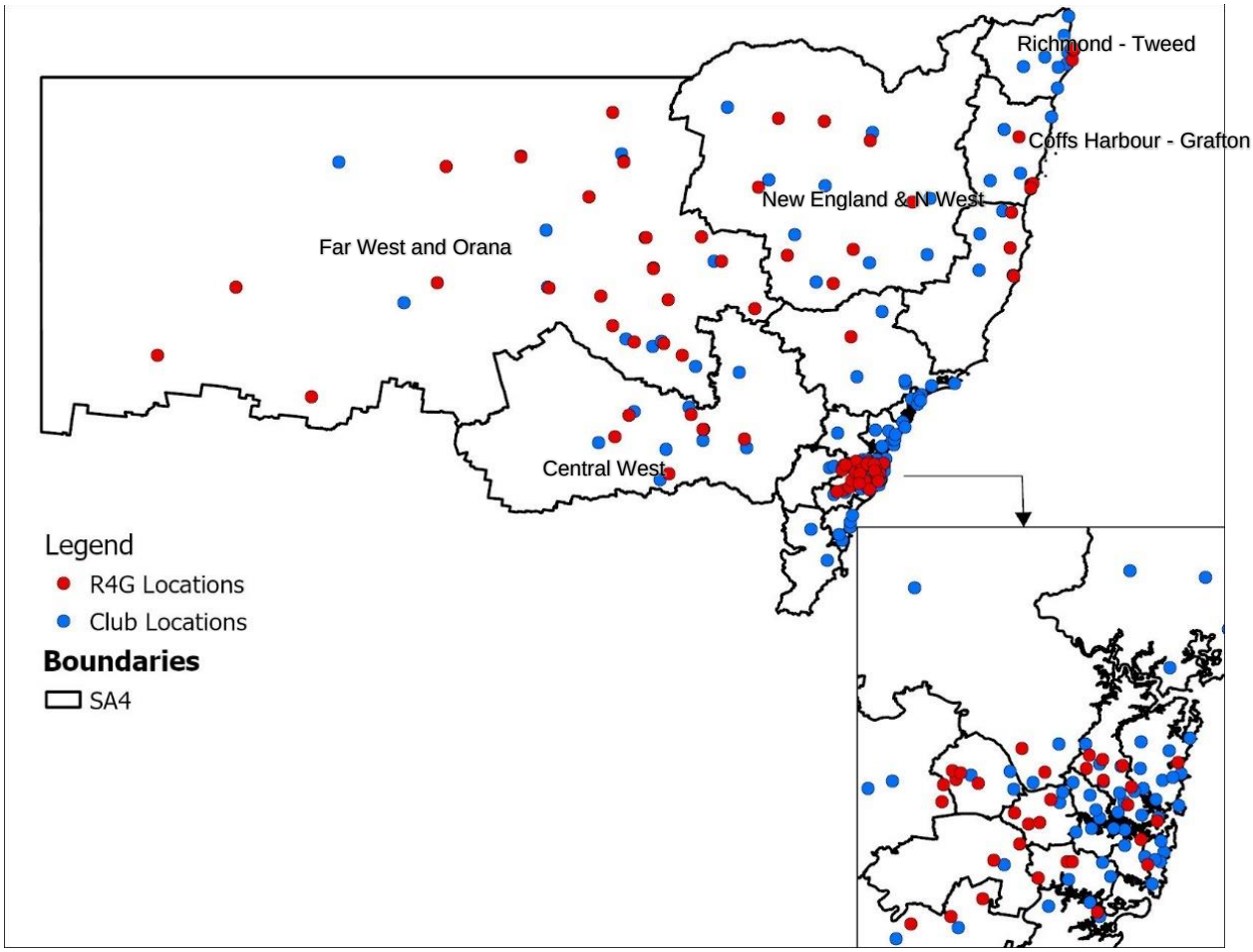
Risk	Proposed mitigation
Unrealistic targets	Given that many of the metrics and programs are relatively new, it is important to regularly test the baseline as more data is collected to set up or adjust targets. Additionally, as programs are expected to grow in the next years, current targets may become outdated and new ones may be needed so that they better align the program's larger reach.
Inadequate & insufficient data collection	Standardised survey development and data collection, including training for staff that will be in charge of administering the surveys. This will allow for better data analysis on the effectiveness of the programs as well as a more seamless integration into the existing program structures.
Insufficient staff & overdependence on key personnel	One of the goals of the *Rugby For Good* model, is to have more sustainable funding, which can lead to more people employed. If this is not achieved, then adequate staffing can become an issue. Update program trainings to include benefit realisation and surveys, so that it is easier for staff with less experience to get involved.
Weak stakeholder engagement	As mentioned before, active participation is needed for a successful. As such, benefit owners must be active to make sure participants are engaged and progress can be monitored. Having regular meetings for ongoing programs, as well as established mechanisms to track and report progress, helps to overcome this risk.

Source: BGA work product

4 APPENDIX: SOCIOECONOMIC PROFILE

The NSW Positive Rugby Foundation region includes much of northern, central and eastern NSW but is largely centred in Sydney, having the largest presence of league club locations in the state. Other key locations include Dubbo and Coffs Harbour, which act as hubs to service and support rugby league programs in surrounding areas. Several clubs are also dispersed in Newcastle, Central Coast, Wollongong, Maitland, Tweed Heads and Port Macquarie and rugby programs have been delivered in Far West and Orana, Mid North Coast, Illawarra, New England and the North West. Figure 4 highlights *Rugby For Good* (R4G) and club locations in NSW. Regions in NSW are grouped by statistical area fours (SA4) to represent labour markets and the functional areas of key cities.

Figure 4. Map of NSW Positive Rugby Foundation Region



Source: BGA work product based on NSW Positive Rugby Foundation data

Long-term NSW economic goals include a high standard of living for the population, a diversified economy, well-connected urban centres, innovative businesses and environmental preservation.[2] The NSW region contains significant railway, airport and road infrastructure enabling domestic and international transport. In particular, Sydney is a global metropolitan city acting as a vast employment and industrial hub. Other cities, such as Dubbo, Wollongong and Coffs Harbour act as regional hubs to maintain and connect regional communities as well as key industries and services. Such industries

[2] NSW Treasury 2019 NSW 2040 Economic Blueprint

include tourism and retail in the Mid-Northern Coast or healthcare and education in the Illawarra, Far West and Orana. In New England and Northern West, the economy is dominated by primary industry, healthcare and local government.[3]

The region boasts diversity in landscapes. Deserts, plains, rainforests, forests and wooded grasslands support the state's biodiversity and a wide range of agricultural industries. The region is also split by the Great Dividing Range, a mountainous barrier between the coast and inland, that prompts large differences in land usage, depending on topography.

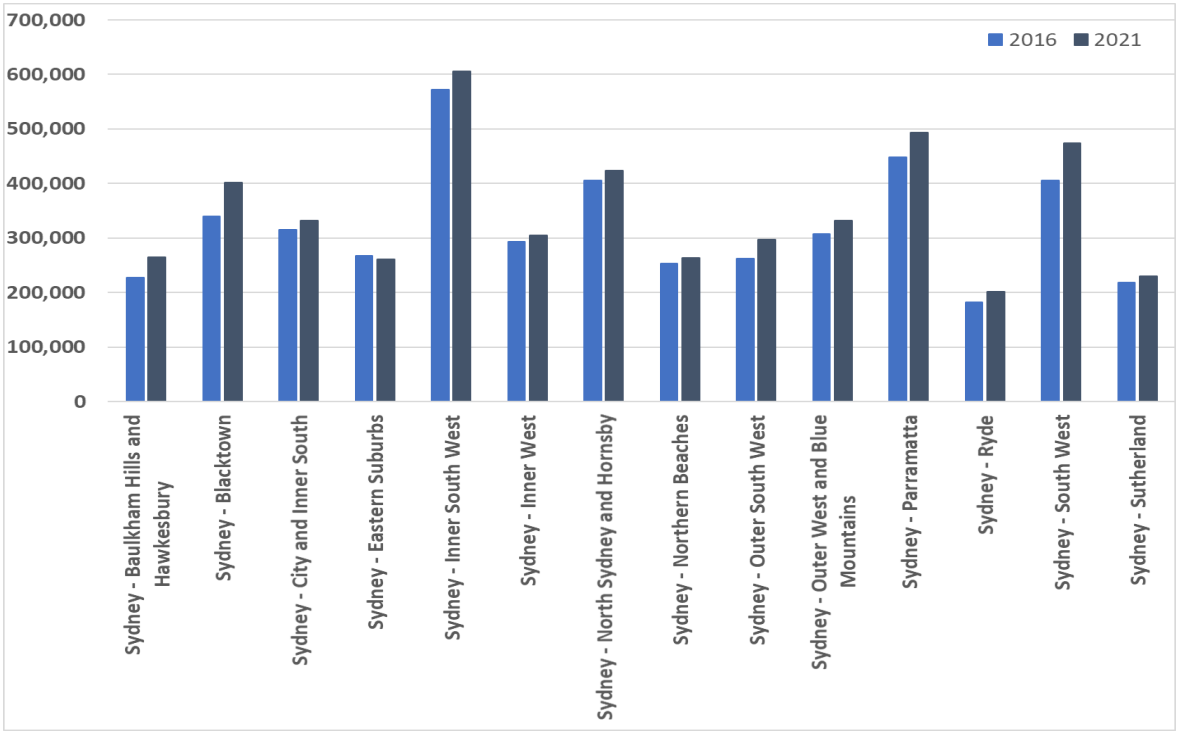
4.1 POPULATION

Population and population growth are important indicators of the viability and effectiveness of sporting programs. Based on national census data from the Australian Bureau of Statistics, from 2016 to 2021, the population has grown across all localities in which NSW Positive Rugby Foundation operates. The collective NSW Positive Rugby Foundation region grew from 6,990,604 in 2016 to 7,534,761 in 2021 but was highest in Sydney and coastal regional centres. The population is also projected to continue increasing until 2041, driven largely by Sydney, Dubbo, Tamworth and key centres along the NSW coast.[4] The majority of the population increase is expected to centre in Greater Sydney, driven by net overseas migration, while residents are projected to marginally decline in Western NSW, driven by an older population and negative internal migration.

As of 2021, most people living in the Rugby NSW region are concentrated in Greater Sydney, home to 5,231,147. This is followed by Newcastle at 390,519 and Wollongong at 129,912. Figure 5 represents the resident population of Greater Sydney broken down by localities in both 2016 and 2021. The Inner South West houses the highest number of people at 600,000 compared to the lowest, Ryde, which houses only 200,000. Further, all localities grew over the past 5 years, except for the Eastern Suburbs. This suggests that investment in Greater Sydney is likely to benefit a large number of people, providing value for money. Further, Sydney is characterised by high cultural diversity, particularly Western Sydney, with a large proportion of people born overseas.

[3] ABS 2021 Census
[4] NSW Planning 2022 Population Projections

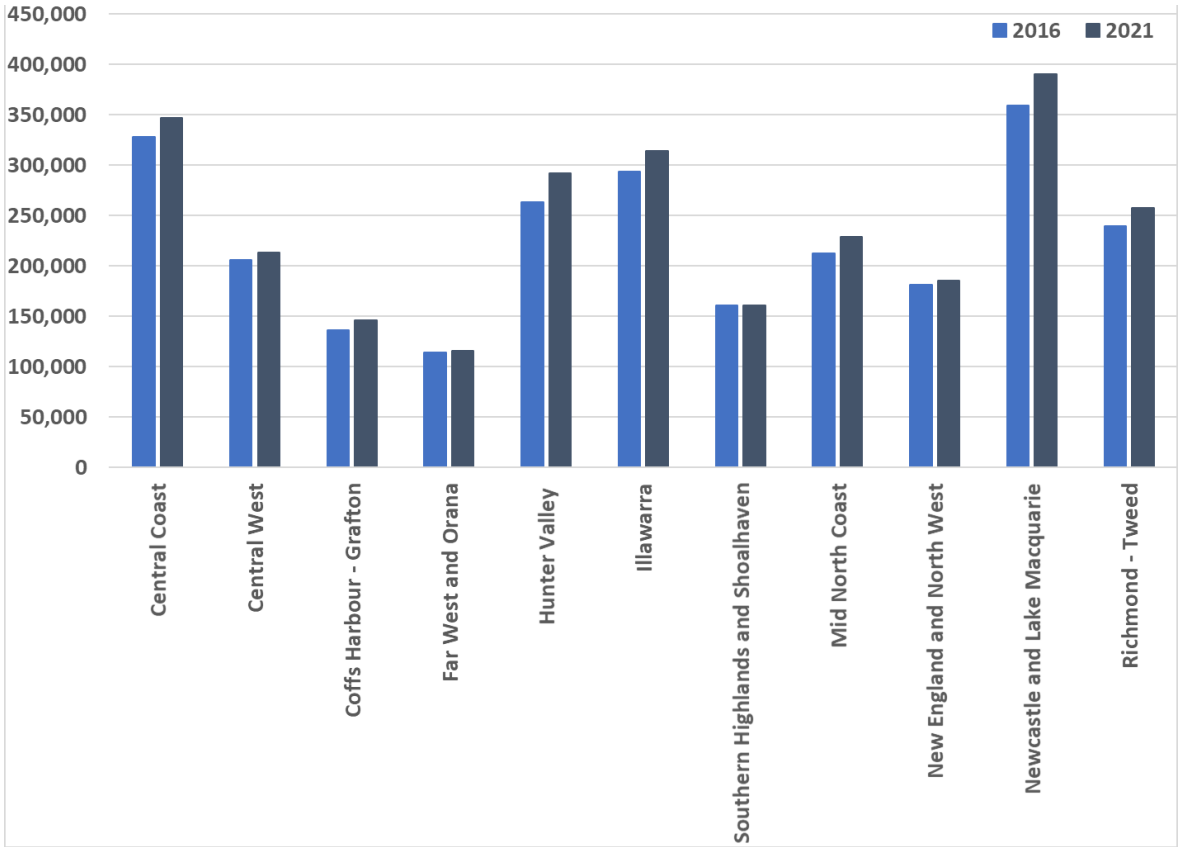
Figure 5. Estimated Resident Population 2016 and 2021 Greater Sydney



Source: BGA work product and Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS), Census 2021.

Figure 6 breaks down the 2016 and 2021 population of regional areas under Rugby NSW. In 2021, the Far West and Orana regions recorded the lowest population at 115,566, characterized by low population density and smaller population centres. This situation presents challenges in delivering services, sporting activities, and programs. In contrast, Newcastle and Lake Macquarie boast a combined population of approximately 390,000, reflecting a high population density. Meanwhile, the Central Coast, with around 350,000 residents, has a more dispersed population. Both Newcastle and Lake Macquarie represent significant opportunities for high returns on investment.

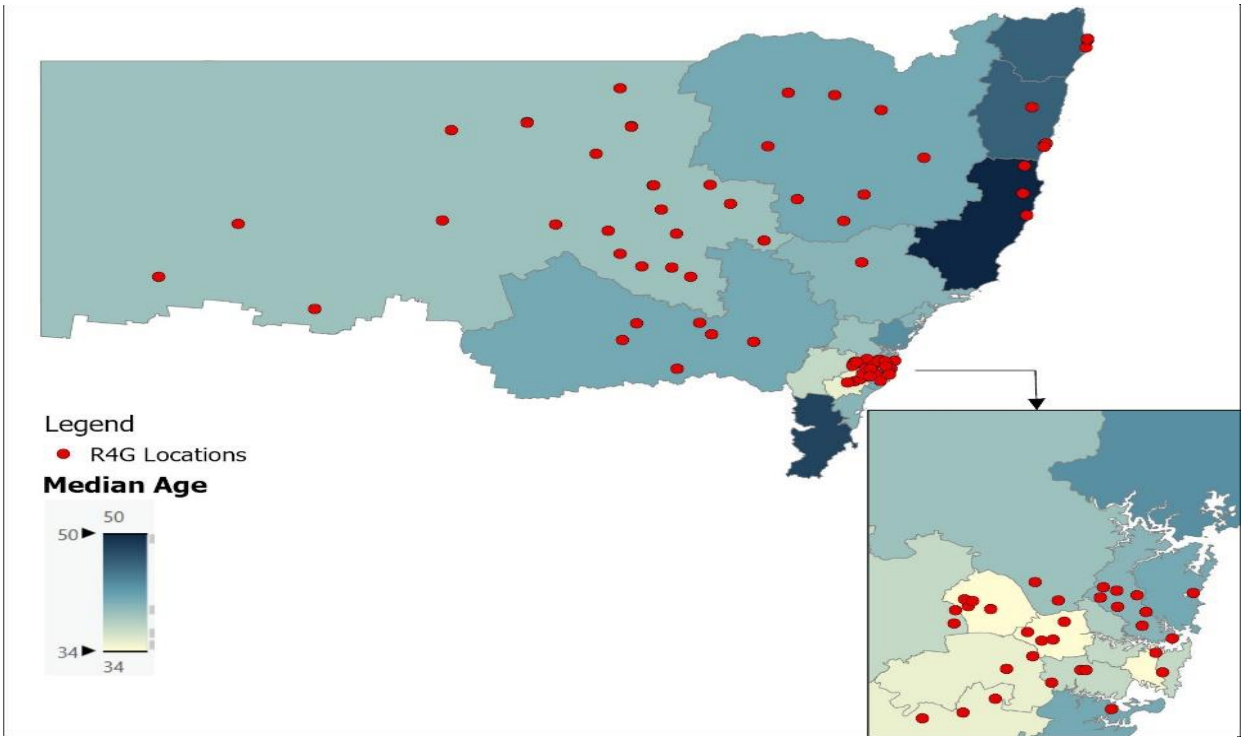
Figure 6. Estimated Resident Population 2016 and 2021 Regional areas



Source: BGA work product and Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS), Census 2021.

Figure 7 illustrates the median age by Statistical Area Level 4 (SA4), serving as an essential indicator of the population's age structure and the overall aging trends. Regions such as the Mid-North Coast and Richmond Tweed have an older demographic, while Western and Central Sydney are home to a younger population. The figure further highlights that areas like Illawarra, Mid North Coast, Coffs Harbour - Grafton, and Richmond Tweed exhibit older age structures. Regions with higher median ages tend to have lower participation rates in sports due to a more senior and less active population.

Figure 7. Median Age (2021)



Source: BGA work product and Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS), Census 2021.

4.2 HOUSING

The majority of the region has experienced housing availability challenges since 2018, with the market tightening significantly since then[5]. Average residential vacancy rates in NSW remain low at 0.9%, however, the entire state, particularly Sydney is facing challenges in rental affordability. In 2023, Sydney and NSW were deemed moderately unaffordable based on the rental affordability index, with residents spending approximately 29% of their income on rent.[6] This indicates that NSW rentals are the second least affordable in the country, behind Queensland where 30% of income is spent on rent.

Between October 2019 and October 2024, the median asking house price in Sydney increased 39% from $1,067,840 to $1,492.978[7]. The house price to income ratio for Sydney is 13.8[8], higher than the NSW benchmark. The rest of the region has lower prices and properties are more affordable. However, there are still housing availability issues and affordability has deteriorated over time.

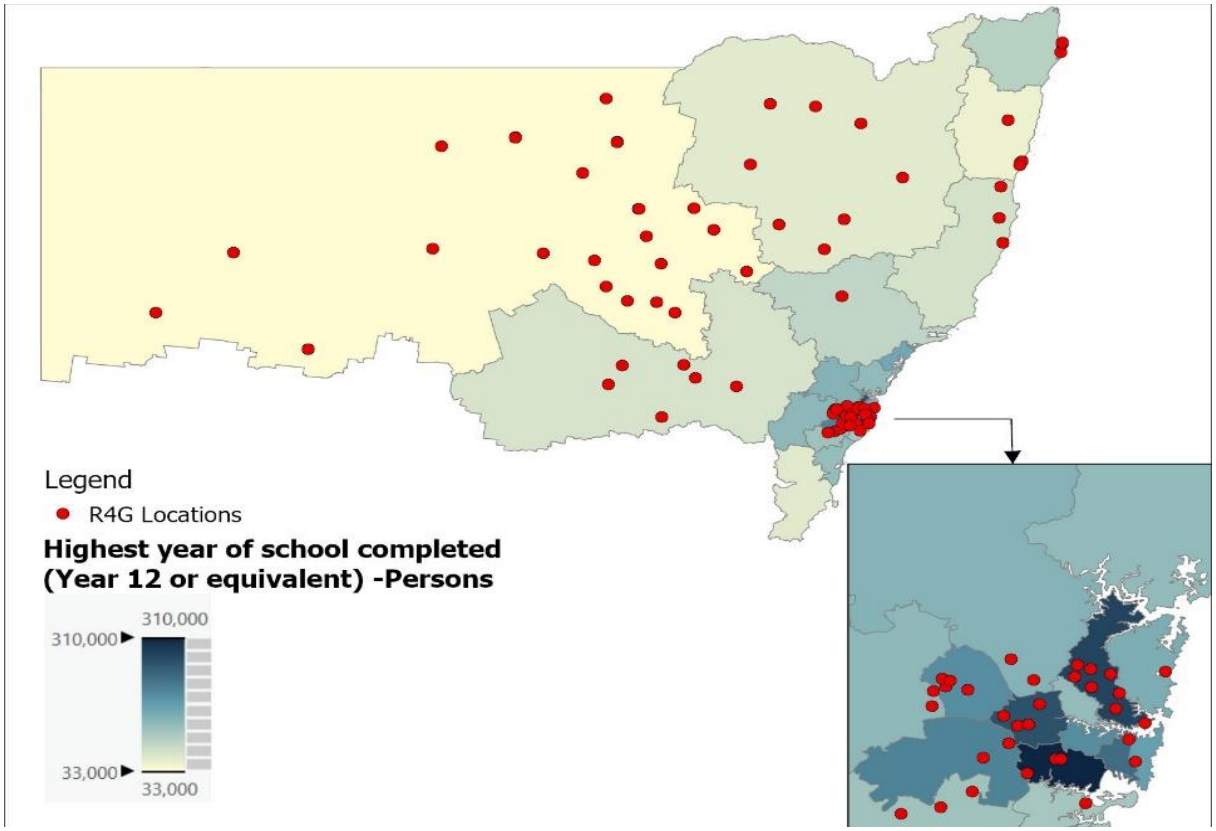
The rental and housing affordability issues present in NSW and Sydney are driven by high demand and tight supply.[9] Demand has been driven by a rising population, as discussed in Section 4.1: Population, and this is only projected to worsen with time. This emphasises constraints in supply, such as a need for dwelling construction workers and bottlenecks in residential housing approvals.

[5] NSW Planning 2024 Current housing pressures
[6] SGS Economics and Planning 2022, Rental Affordability Index
[7] SQM Research 2024
[8] Demographia International Housing Affordability 2024 Report
[9] NSW Planning 2021 Regional Housing Taskforce Findings Report

4.3 EDUCATION

Levels of education and qualifications can inform the degree to which socio-economic areas can adapt to new economic conditions, as well as the influence of policy on behaviour. The proportion of students completing high school in Australia has been on the rise from 2016 to 2021. Far West and Orana contain the lowest number of people completing year 12, largely due to a lower population. On the other hand, Sydney has the highest quantity of people completing year 12 and therefore higher educational outcomes, a trend amongst all major cities in Australia. Figure 8 displays the number of people completing year 12 or equivalent across NSW. A general trend indicates that more people complete high school closer to Sydney, however, this is likely driven by population differences. This trend is supported by the proportion of students who complete year 12 in Greater Sydney being higher at 64.5% than in regional areas.

Figure 8. People who completed year 12 or equivalent 2021



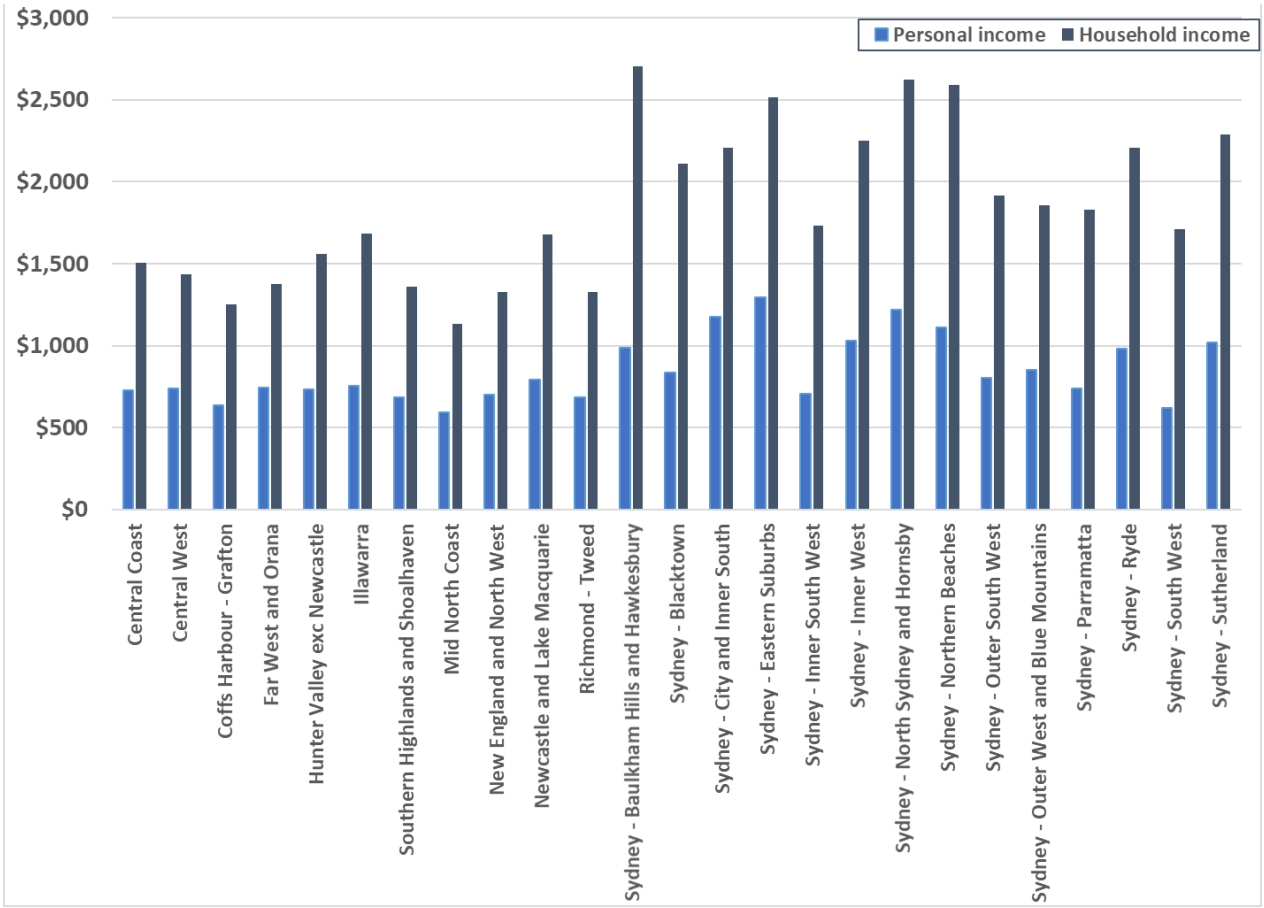
Source: BGA work product and Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS), Census 2021.

4.4 INCOME

Household income is calculated by summating the personal incomes reported by all household members aged 15 years and over and is collected via the Survey of Income and Housing. Income data is reported in ranges, so the median for each range is used in calculations. When combined with other data, such as home ownership, mortgage/rent repayments, education and employment data, household income provides insights for social and community planning and development.

Figure 9 highlights that personal and household incomes are highest in Eastern, Northern and North-Western Sydney, and are lowest in the Mid-North Coast and Coffs Harbour - Grafton. Incomes in other areas such as Wollongong and Western NSW are slightly below the NSW and national average but are higher than the Australian median, indicating that while income is lower in some areas of NSW, these areas still compare quite well to the rest of Australia. Nominal income has also been steadily rising over time as both household and personal median incomes in NSW have increased by 22% from 2016 to 2021.[10]

Figure 9. Weekly Household and Personal Income



Source: BGA work product Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS), Census 2021.

4.5 INDUSTRY

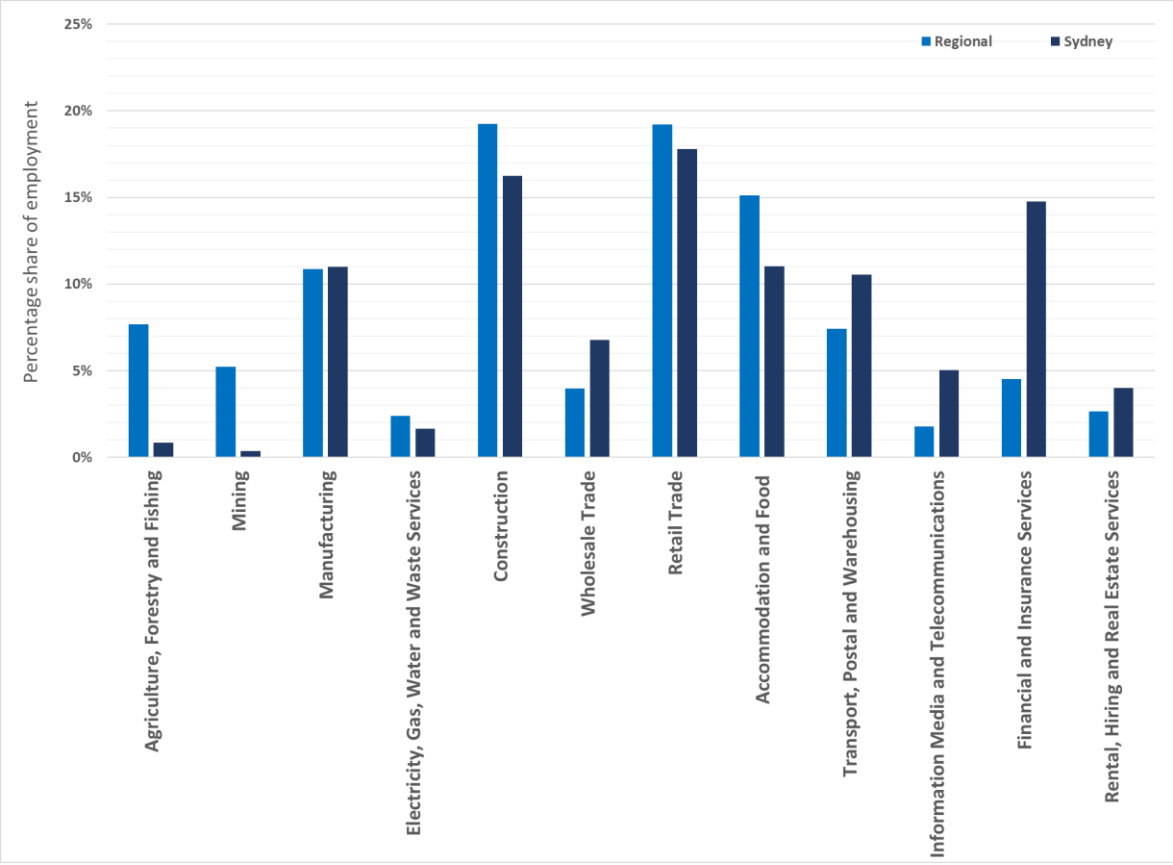
NSW has large and diversified industries with strong investment, economic growth and opportunities. Recently economic output in 2022-23 has been driven by transport, postal and warehousing as well as accommodation and food services.[11] Sydney acts as a hub for economic activity, contributing to the vast majority of NSW's output and providing a significant source of employment, especially in services industries. Comparatively, regional areas make a smaller contribution to economic output due to lower population and relatively smaller industries.

[10] Snapshot of New South Wales, ABS
[11] ABS 2024 National Accounts

Over time, the NSW economy has shifted away from resource-intensive industries to service industries with the main industries being retail, construction, accommodation and food and manufacturing. Figure 10 breaks down industries of employment for regional NSW and Sydney in 2021, displaying industries by their percentage share of total employment in both areas. In Sydney, retail trade (18%), construction (16%) and financial services (15%) are the three most popular industries while in regional NSW it is construction (19%), retail (19%) and accommodation and food (15%). Rural and inland economies tend to be more dominated by agriculture and service industries, while Sydney displays a greater diversity or spread of employment across a variety of industries.

Sporting tourism in NSW also represents an opportunity for growth, given the large number of sporting events, competitions and facilities. In leveraging these assets, rugby is promoted and participation in sport is encouraged at all levels. Tourism is discussed in further detail in Section 4.7 Tourism.

Figure 10. Employment by Industry 2021



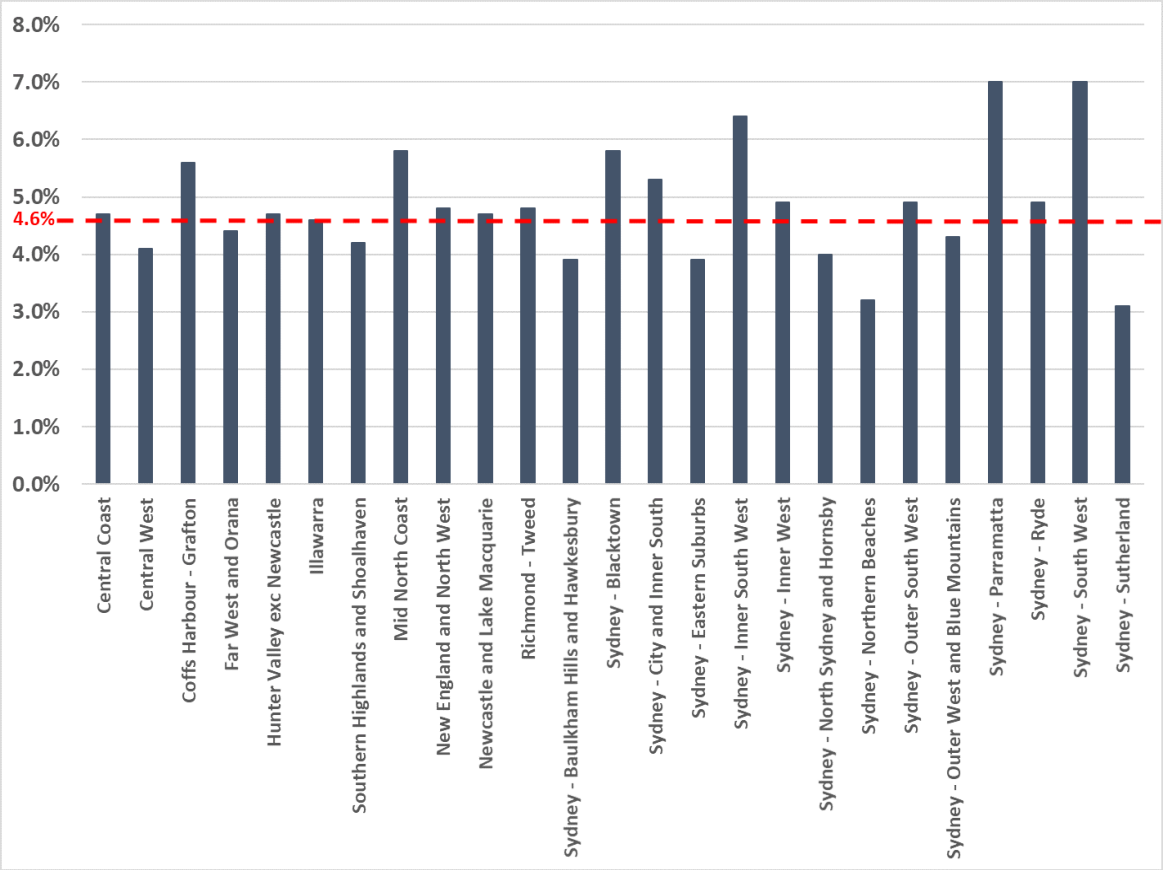
Source: BGA work product Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS), Census 2021

4.6 UNEMPLOYMENT

Unemployment is a key indicator of health in labour markets, hence, Figure 11 provides a snapshot of 2021 unemployment rates in key regions. The highest rates of unemployment are in Paramatta and Sydney's South West (7%) which are both much higher than the NSW benchmark of 4.6%, indicated by a red line in the figure. Unemployment rates are lower in the northern beaches and Sutherland (both at 3.2%) and outside of Sydney, they are lowest in the southern highlands and Shoalhaven (4.2%) as well as the Central West (4.1%).

Unemployment in NSW has remained steady and low since its peak at 7.1% in July 2020, an effect of COVID-19.[12] Prior to this, average employment levels hovered between 4 and 5% but since recovering from the COVID-19 shock, the new stable levels are between 3 and 4%, based on estimates made by the ABS in 2024.

Figure 11. Unemployment Rate 2021



Source: BGA work product Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS), Census 2021.

4.7 TOURISM

Tourism is a leading sector in NSW, having the largest share of visitors, nights and expenditure in the country. In the year ending June 2024, NSW welcomed 97.9 million domestic visitors, who spent $40.7 billion and stayed a total of 117 million nights.[13] International visitors totalled 3.7 million, spending $12.2 billion and staying 99.1 million nights.

Since last year, domestic and international visitors in NSW have decreased by 3.6% (about 4 million), however, the large increase in nights (18.3% or 34 million) has meant that tourist spending has climbed by an impressive 9% ($4.5 billion). This means sectors that are dependent on tourism, such as hospitality and accommodation sectors would likely have seen growth and that outcomes in the regional economy such as employment and income would have been boosted as a result of tourism. A large portion of visitation and spending is also concentrated in Greater Sydney, accounting for

[12] Labour Force Australia, ABS
[13] Destination NSW 2024, NSW Insights

51% of total tourist spending in NSW. This is reflective of Sydney's greater population, and increased number of businesses, attractions and experiences.

4.8 NSW BIODIVERSITY

New South Wales contains a range of environments, topographies and landscapes, lying in the temperate zone. Threats to the region's rich biodiversity and unique environments include inappropriate land use practices, invasive species, soil degradation (such as erosion, salinity, or land contamination), illegal dumping, littering, coastal erosion, infrastructure development and climate change. Over 1000 threatened species have become at risk of becoming extinct due to habitat loss, jeopardising the area's agricultural, social and environmental values[14]

[14] NSW Department of Environment 2024